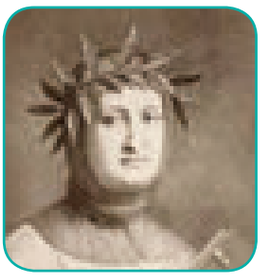
Florence as Home of Renaissance

Renaissance in Literature



Dante



Petrarch

Even in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries Florence had produced Dante (1265-1321) and Petrarch, the two great poets of the Italian language. Dante's *Divine Comedy* is a summation of medieval culture. Its dominant theme is the salvation of mankind through reason and divine grace. But it abounds with many other themes such as human love, love of country, interest in natural phenomena and even the desire for a free and united Italian nation.

Petrarch (1304-1374) produced works both in Latin and Italian. An early humanist, he is considered to be the father of Italian Renaissance literature. Petrarch's inquiring mind and love of classical authors led him to travel, visiting men of learning and searching in monastic libraries for classical manuscripts. It is believed that his rediscovery of Cicero's letters was a key moment in the 14th century Italian Renaissance.

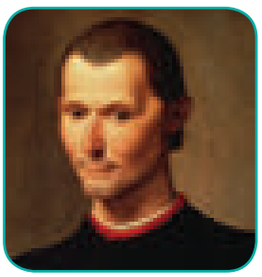
Giovanni Boccaccio (1313–1375), also a Florentine, produced *Decameron*, a collection of 100 stories, as told by seven young women and three young men, during their stay at a villa outside of Florence to escape the ravages of the Black Death.



Boccaccio

Niccolò Machiavelli (1469–1527)

Niccolò Machiavelli's *The Prince* became famous because of its relevance as a political guide for the rulers. In his view, the supreme obligation of the ruler was to maintain the power and safety of the country over which he ruled. No consideration of justice or mercy or the sanctity of treaties should be allowed to stand in his way. Machiavelli maintained that all men are prompted exclusively by motives of self-interest and the head of the state should therefore take nothing for granted as to the loyalty or affection of his subjects.



Machiavelli

'A Prince' says Machiavelli, 'must know how to play at once man and beast, lion and fox. He neither should nor can keep his word when to do so will turn against him…. I venture to maintain that it is very disadvantageous always to be honest; useful on the other hand, to appear pious and faithful, humane and devout. Nothing is more useful than the appearance of virtue.'

Renaissance in Art

Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519)



Leonardo da Vinci

In Florence there was an artist who wanted to have a perfect understanding of all the things he painted and how they related to each other. This was Leonardo da Vinci, the son of a farm servant-girl. So he was a self-taught man in Latin and Mathematics. He was also a sculptor, a great thinker and scientist. He got corpses from graveyards to dissect and understand human anatomy so that he could depict human bodies realistically. He was the first to discover that blood circulated through the body. Given his multifaceted talents da Vinci is considered to be a great example of the Renaissance Man.

Leonardo da Vinci's masterpieces include *Virgin of the Rocks, Last Supper* and *Mona Lisa*. In *Virgin of the Rocks*, the Virgin Mary, emerging from darkness, presents the young John the

12th_History_EM_Unit_10.indd 132 24-03-2020 10:03:57